NEW YORK, UNITED STATES

The Metropolitan Museum of Art: Masterpieces

Small actions organise crowded landscapes, formal portraits and scenes of public drama.



The workers eating beneath Bruegel's tree are easy to find, though their meal occupies only a small part of an extensive landscape. David gives a reaching hand a different task: the cup beside Socrates determines the meaning of the whole scene. Across this selection from the Metropolitan Museum of Art, people touch, carry, reach, wait and turn. Following those actions offers a manageable way into pictures with very different subjects. It also reveals what a gesture cannot tell us. A sitter's direct gaze is not evidence of freedom, as the history of Juan de Pareja makes clear; a seemingly spontaneous gathering can be carefully arranged.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/metropolitan-museum

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    Élisabeth Vigée Le Brun · 1789

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The Harvesters

Pieter Bruegel the Elder

1565 · Oil on wood · The Metropolitan Museum of Art



Rogers Fund, 1919. The Metropolitan Museum of Art. CC0; compressed study reproduction. · CC0 1.0

Beneath the tree, a meal interrupts the work continuing in the grain beyond. Bruegel lets us move between these near bodies and a district of fields, paths and distant water. The apparent completeness of the view is constructed, not a survey of one actual place. Commissioned for a wealthy patron, this abundant countryside offers an ordered image of labour as well as many closely observed details.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 19.164

02 / 20

Aristotle with a Bust of Homer

Rembrandt van Rijn

1653 · Oil on canvas · The Metropolitan Museum of Art



Purchase, special contributions and funds given or bequeathed by friends of the Museum, 1961. The Metropolitan Museum of Art. CC0. · CC0 1.0

Aristotle's hand rests on Homer's stone head, joining a living figure to a sculpted one. The sleeve and gold chain catch light that leaves much of his face less accessible. Rembrandt gives the eye several materials to compare before it attempts to explain the philosopher's thought. The gesture is definite; its inward meaning remains open, held between touch, possession and the presence of an earlier poet.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 61.198

03 / 20

View of Toledo

El Greco

c. 1599–1600 · Oil on canvas · The Metropolitan Museum of Art



H. O. Havemeyer Collection, Bequest of Mrs. H. O. Havemeyer, 1929. The Metropolitan Museum of Art. CC0. Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression to at most 100,000 bytes; no crop or generated content. · CC0 1.0

The city's pale buildings climb a green ridge beneath a dark, broken sky. El Greco makes their boundaries unusually forceful: architecture that might ordinarily provide a setting becomes the chief actor. The bridge and walls connect separate stretches of ground, while changes of light keep those connections tense. There is no need to invent an approaching catastrophe to notice how unstable the weather makes the familiar outline appear.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 29.100.6

04 / 20

Juan de Pareja

Diego Velázquez

1650 · Oil on canvas · The Metropolitan Museum of Art



Purchase, Fletcher and Rogers Funds, and Bequest of Miss Adelaide Milton de Groot (1876-1967), by exchange, supplemented by gifts from friends of the Museum, 1971. The Metropolitan Museum of Art. CC0; compressed study reproduction. · CC0 1.0

A white collar separates Pareja's face from subdued clothing and background. His direct gaze and arm drawn across the body give the portrait considerable firmness. That presence must not obscure his circumstances: when Velázquez painted him, Pareja was enslaved in the painter's household and studio. He later became free and established his own career as an artist. The picture alone cannot tell that history.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1971.86

05 / 20

The Death of Socrates

Jacques-Louis David

1787 · Oil on canvas · The Metropolitan Museum of Art



Catharine Lorillard Wolfe Collection, Wolfe Fund, 1931. The Metropolitan Museum of Art. CC0. · CC0 1.0

Socrates reaches towards the poison while raising his other hand. David divides the action between accepting the cup and continuing to speak, giving the central body a firmness absent from the bowed and turning figures around it. Their grief helps define his composure. The scene's argument depends on that contrast of postures, not simply on knowing which man is about to die.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 31.45

06 / 20

The Horse Fair

Rosa Bonheur

1852–55 · Oil on canvas · The Metropolitan Museum of Art



Gift of Cornelius Vanderbilt, 1887. The Metropolitan Museum of Art. CC0; compressed study reproduction. · CC0 1.0

Horses turn across the foreground as their handlers pull the reins. Bonheur makes the individual efforts readable within a larger circuit: a head changes direction, a body follows, another animal presses close. White coats separate parts of the group from darker horses and trees. The orderly composition does not remove the difficulty of managing these bodies; it gives their weight and competing movements room to register.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 87.25

07 / 20

The Dance Class

Edgar Degas

1874 · Oil on canvas · The Metropolitan Museum of Art



Bequest of Mrs. Harry Payne Bingham, 1986. The Metropolitan Museum of Art. CC0. Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression to at most 100,000 bytes; no crop or generated content. · CC0 1.0

The dancers do not all perform the same action. Some wait, others stretch or adjust clothing, while the floorboards lead past them towards the crowded back of the room. Degas gives rehearsal a dispersed rhythm, unlike the coordinated appearance of a stage performance. Attention can wander among unfinished preparations. These pauses belong to the work of dancing, though they would normally fall outside its public presentation.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1987.47.1

08 / 20

Wheat Field with Cypresses

Vincent van Gogh

1889 · Oil on canvas · The Metropolitan Museum of Art



Purchase, The Annenberg Foundation Gift, 1993. The Metropolitan Museum of Art. CC0. Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression to at most 100,000 bytes; no crop or generated content. · CC0 1.0

Curving strokes pass through the wheat, hills and rounded clouds, linking areas that remain distinct in colour. The dark cypress supplies an upright interruption. Without it, the repeated curves might spread more evenly across the view; beside it, their movement becomes easier to measure. Van Gogh's marks describe different things while keeping a visible kinship, so the landscape's parts belong to one painted surface as well as one place.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1993.132

09 / 20

The Card Players

Paul Cézanne

1890–92 · Oil on canvas · The Metropolitan Museum of Art



Bequest of Stephen C. Clark, 1960. The Metropolitan Museum of Art. CC0; compressed study reproduction. · CC0 1.0

Three players gather around the table, with two other figures watching. Their lowered faces and bent arms contain attention within the group. Cézanne gives the bodies substantial, separate shapes rather than making them disappear into the exchange of a game. Cards provide the immediate reason for the gathering, but the painting's durability comes from the arrangement of people who seem unlikely to move for our benefit.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 61.101.1

10 / 20

Garden at Sainte-Adresse

Claude Monet

1867 · Oil on canvas · The Metropolitan Museum of Art



Claude Monet. Garden at Sainte-Adresse. Image credit: Claude Monet; The Metropolitan Museum of Art. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Claude_Monet_-_Jardin_%C3%A0_Sainte-Adresse.jpg. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

Seated figures look towards the sea while a pair stands at the terrace rail. Flowers, water and sky form broad horizontal divisions, crossed by flagpoles. Monet makes a place for looking outward while preserving the decorative clarity of those stacked bands. The people occupy a measured garden foreground; beyond them, the water extends into a space that the terrace frames but cannot contain.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 67.241

11 / 20

Boating

Édouard Manet

1874 · Oil on canvas · The Metropolitan Museum of Art



H. O. Havemeyer Collection, Bequest of Mrs. H. O. Havemeyer, 1929. The Metropolitan Museum of Art. CC0; compressed study reproduction. · CC0 1.0

Water fills almost all the space behind the man in white and woman in blue. With no distant horizon to pull the eye away, their boat comes unusually close. Its diagonal cuts through broad areas of colour rather than leading towards a conventional landscape view. Manet makes the cropping part of the leisure scene: the outing is visible only as an encounter already in progress.

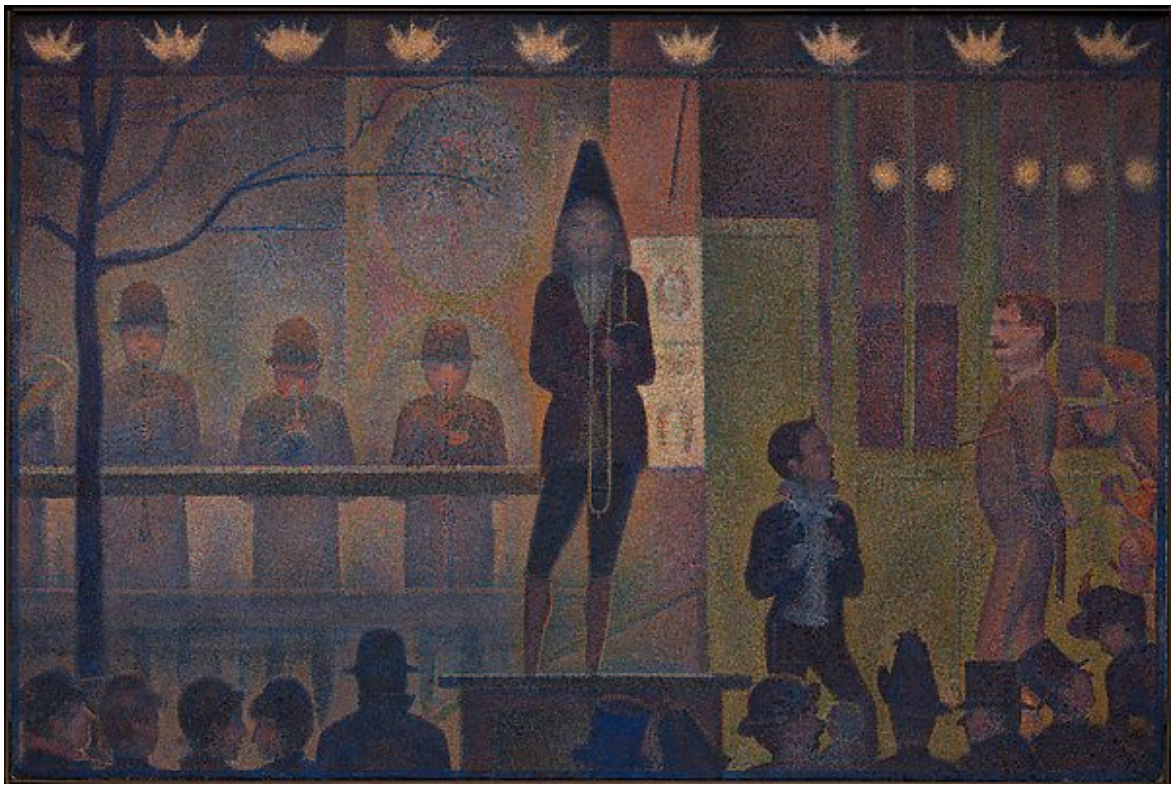
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 29.100.115

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Circus Sideshow

Georges Seurat

1887–88 · Oil on canvas · The Metropolitan Museum of Art



Bequest of Stephen C. Clark, 1960. The Metropolitan Museum of Art. CC0; compressed study reproduction. · CC0 1.0

The dark heads of spectators form a lower band beneath musicians and a row of lights. Seurat separates those levels so clearly that the entertainment seems almost held in place. Repeated upright forms give a measured order to a subject associated with noise and movement. The central player is conspicuous, yet no individual gesture releases the scene from its carefully maintained distance.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 61.101.17

13 / 20

Antoine Laurent and Marie Anne Lavoisier

Jacques-Louis David

1788 · Oil on canvas · The Metropolitan Museum of Art



Purchase, Mr. and Mrs. Charles Wrightsman Gift, in honor of Everett Fahy, 1977. The Metropolitan Museum of Art. CC0. · CC0 1.0

Marie Anne stands beside her seated husband, her pale dress rising above the red table covering and glass apparatus. Their linked poses give the instruments a human setting. Her presence is more than decorative: she recorded experiments and illustrated scientific publications. David's arrangement lets the couple's relationship be recognised before each piece of equipment is named, while the apparatus identifies a shared field of work.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1977.10

14 / 20

A Woman Seated beside a Vase of Flowers (Madame Paul Valpinçon?)

Edgar Degas

1865 · Oil on canvas · The Metropolitan Museum of Art



H. O. Havemeyer Collection, Bequest of Mrs. H. O. Havemeyer, 1929. The Metropolitan Museum of Art. CC0. Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression to at most 100,000 bytes; no crop or generated content. · CC0 1.0

The flowers take the central position that a portrait would usually reserve for its sitter. Pushed towards the right edge, the woman rests a hand near her face and looks away. Degas makes her apparent distraction coincide with our divided attention: we must choose between face and bouquet. The question mark in the proposed identification matters; the unusual arrangement is clearer than the woman's identity.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 29.100.128

15 / 20

Bridge over a Pond of Water Lilies

Claude Monet

1899 · Oil on canvas · The Metropolitan Museum of Art



Claude Monet, Bridge over a Pond of Water Lilies. The Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York. Reproduction: Daniel Schwen, via Wikimedia Commons (PD-Art). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression to at most 100,000 bytes; no crop or generated content. · Public Domain Mark 1.0 / PD-Art

The bridge provides a recognisable span above water crowded with lilies and reflected growth. Plants close the distance behind it, leaving little open sky. Monet's surface therefore asks for repeated distinctions between things and their reflections, distinctions that colour alone does not always settle. The bridge offers a firm crossing, but below it the pond gathers near leaves and more distant vegetation into the same shallow-looking field.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 29.100.113

16 / 20

Shrovetide Revellers

Frans Hals

c. 1615 · Oil on canvas · The Metropolitan Museum of Art



Frans Hals. Shrovetide Revellers (The Merry Company). WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/frans-hals/shrovetide-revellers-the-merry-company · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Faces, hands, food and costume crowd the front of Hals's picture. Open mouths and overlapping gestures imply exchanges that do not stay neatly within the group: several figures appear to address someone beyond the frame. The close packing removes the comfortable distance of a spectator surveying a room. Instead, the picture places us near an unruly gathering whose individual conversations remain difficult to disentangle.

Object source · Open artwork

17 / 20

Blind Orion Searching for the Rising Sun

Nicolas Poussin

1658 · Oil on canvas · The Metropolitan Museum of Art



Fletcher Fund, 1924. The Metropolitan Museum of Art. CC0. · CC0 1.0

Orion's huge body moves through trees and clouds while a much smaller figure rides on his shoulder. Poussin makes their difference in size unmistakable without dividing them into separate worlds. The continuous landscape accommodates both the giant's stride and the people below. Myth enters through scale: familiar ground becomes capable of holding a body that exceeds the usual measure of its inhabitants.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 24.45.1

18 / 20

Cardinal Fernando Niño de Guevara

El Greco

c. 1600 · Oil on canvas · The Metropolitan Museum of Art



H. O. Havemeyer Collection, Bequest of Mrs. H. O. Havemeyer, 1929. The Metropolitan Museum of Art. CC0. Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression to at most 100,000 bytes; no crop or generated content. · CC0 1.0

Red robes spread across the seated figure, while the angular chair and tiled floor establish a firmer geometry. El Greco keeps the cardinal's face small but precise within this display of office. Spectacles and the direct gaze arrest attention; hands provide further interruptions to the silk's flow. Official dress does not erase the individual, though it determines much of the space through which we encounter him.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 29.100.5

19 / 20

A Bouquet of Flowers

Clara Peeters

c. 1612 · Oil on wood · The Metropolitan Museum of Art



Purchase, Lila Acheson Wallace, Howard S. and Nancy Marks, Friends of European Paintings, and Mr. and Mrs. J. Tomilson Hill Gifts, Gift of Humanities Fund Inc., by exchange, Henry and Lucy Moses Fund Inc. Gift, and funds from various donors, 2020. The Metropolitan Museum of Art. CC0. Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression to at most 100,000 bytes; no crop or generated content. · CC0 1.0

Peeters extends the still life beyond the upright bouquet. Fallen blossoms, shells and small objects occupy the ledge beneath the dark vase, giving the eye a second, lower area to inspect. The difference between attached and detached flowers makes their fragility specific rather than merely symbolic. The arrangement has been assembled, but its scattered pieces also suggest how readily an arrangement can come apart.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2020.22

20 / 20

Comtesse de la Châtre

Élisabeth Vigée Le Brun

1789 · Oil on canvas · The Metropolitan Museum of Art



Gift of Jessie Woolworth Donahue, 1954. The Metropolitan Museum of Art. CC0. · CC0 1.0

An open book establishes an activity that the sitter's turn appears to interrupt. Vigée Le Brun gives the formal pose an implied sequence: reading, then looking towards someone nearby. The dark hat and ribbon frame the pale dress and face without competing with that small change of attention. The picture does not record an interruption we can verify; it makes a sustained pose look temporarily available.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 54.182

Follow one action across several pictures

Compare the comtesse turning from her book with Cézanne's players, who remain absorbed in theirs, or Socrates' outstretched hand with Aristotle's resting one. Such comparisons need not imply a historical connection between artists. This is a selection of paintings, not a survey of the Met's entire collection or a guaranteed gallery route. Check current object records before planning a visit around particular works.

Further reading

Dutch Paintings in The Metropolitan Museum of Art, Volumes I and II

Walter Liedtke · Read online or download · English

Walter Liedtke's catalogue gives detailed entries on the Met's Dutch paintings, including Rembrandt and Hals. The museum provides the two-volume book to read online or download.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12